William J. Kezerian

Curriculum Vitae

Department of Linguistics
University of Pennsylvania
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Research Interests

Broad Syntax, French-based Creoles, computational linguistics, fieldwork, and bilingualism.

Narrow Language contact, Guadeloupean Creole, NLP, complementation, reduplicative focus fronting, and experimental methods.

Education

2026- **PhD, Linguistics**, University of Pennsylvania
Advisor: Marlyse Baptista

2026 **MA, Linguistic Studies**, Syracuse University
Concentration in NLP
Thesis: Complementation in Guadeloupean Creole: An Experimental and Computational Account. *Advisor: Jaklin Kornfilt*

2024 **BA, Linguistics, Comparative Literature**, University of Massachusetts Amherst
Summa Cum Laude; Minor in French and Francophone Studies

2023 Certificate in TESOL

Summer Schools, Exchanges

2025 VII International Summer School in Language Policy and Language Planning, The University for Foreigners of Siena, Siena, Italy

2025 NASSLLI, the University of Washington, Seattle, Washington

2024 ESSLLI, KU Leuven, Leuven, Belgium

2019 Lycée Dumont d'Urville - LaPlace, Caen, France
Exchange student; TA in Intermediate English

Publications

Chapters in Edited Volumes

in revision **Kezerian, W.**[1] , Jeannot-Fourcaud, B., Barrière, I., & Govain, R. (in revision). *Focus and fronting in Guadeloupean Creole: The role of complementation in focus.* O. Duplâtre & P.-Y. Modicom (Eds.), *Issues in the formal and functional typology of focus.* John Benjamins.

Peer-Reviewed Conference Proceedings

2024 **Kezerian, W.**[1], Wyner, L. A., Ansari, S., & Yu, K. M. "Ye Olde French: Effect of Old and Middle French on SIGMORPHON-UniMorph Shared Task Data." In *Proceedings of the 21st SIGMORPHON Workshop on Computational Research in Phonetics, Phonology, and Morphology* (pp. 39–50), Mexico City, Mexico. Association for Computational Linguistics. LINK

[1] First author

Edited Volumes

2023 Nguyen, K., **Kezerian, W.**, Weaver, S., & Iwanicki, L. (Eds.). (2023). *mOthertongue 2023 (Full Issue).* mOthertongue, 28(1). Comparative Literature Program, University of Massachusetts Amherst.

Peer-Reviewed Conference Presentations

2026 **Kezerian, W.**, Jeannot-Fourcaud, B., Barrière, I., & Govain, R. "Complementizer *kè* Variation in Guadeloupean Creole: Experimental Judgments and Spontaneous Speech." To be presented at *the 17th International Colloquium of Creole Studies*, Schœlcher, Martinique.

2026 **Kezerian, W.**, Jeannot-Fourcaud, B., Barrière, I., & Govain, R. "Complementizer Variation in Guadeloupean Creole: An Empirical and Experimental Approach." To be presented at *The 54th New Ways of Analyzing Variation (NWAV 54)*, Université de Montréal, Montreal, Canada.

2026 **Kezerian, W.**, Jeannot-Fourcaud, B., Barrière, I., & Govain, R. "Relative Attachment: Long-distance PP adjunct attachment in Guadeloupean Creole." Presented at the *Society for Pidgin and Creole Linguistics Winter Meeting 2026*, in conjunction with the *LSA 2026 Winter Meeting*, New Orleans, USA.

2025 **Kezerian, W.**, Tselioudis, V., Jeannot-Fourcaud, B., Barrière, I., & Govain, R. "The Role of *kè* in Guadeloupean Creole Complementation: A comparative syntactic analysis." Presented at *Syntax of the World's Languages X*, University of Potsdam, Potsdam, Germany.

2025 **Kezerian, W.**, Tselioudis, V., Jeannot-Fourcaud, B., Barrière, I., & Govain, R. "Focus and Fronting in Guadeloupean Creole: Examining the role of complementation in focus." Presented at the *SLE 2025 Workshop: Issues in the formal and functional typology of focus*, Université Bordeaux Montaigne, Bordeaux, France.

2024 **Kezerian, W.**, Wyner, L. A., Ansari, S., & Yu, K. M. "Ye Olde French: Effect of Old and Middle French on SIGMORPHON-UniMorph Shared Task Data." Presented at the *SIGMORPHON Workshop*, ACL 2024, Mexico City, Mexico.

Invited Talks

2026 "Complementation in Guadeloupean Creole: An Experimental and Computational Account." Presented at the *4th Annual Linguistic Studies Research and Creative Scholarship Fest*, Syracuse University, NY.

2025 "Testing Clause Boundaries: Focus and Complementation in Guadeloupean Creole." Presented to *The Research Group on Creole Grammars (GRGC)*, Structures Formelles du Langage, Université Paris 8, France.

2025 "Creole for the Classroom: Linguistic documentation and NLP in empowering native-language education in Guadeloupe." Presented at *the VII International Summer School Language Policy and Language Planning: Bilingual minds and translingual practices in multicultural contexts*, The University for Foreigners of Siena, Italy.

2025 "NLP in Language Documentation: A case study on Guadeloupean Creole focus and fronting." Presented at the *Linguistic Studies Program Research and Creative Scholarship Fest*, Syracuse University, NY.

2025 "Linguistic interaction in Guadeloupean Creole oral histories: Call and response to facilitate the tradition's survival." Presented at the *French Graduate Colloquium*, Syracuse University, NY.

2024 "Subordinate clauses in Guadeloupean Creole: Complementizer dropping, NP/VP focus, and PP focus attachment." Presented at the *NSF-IRES Conference*, University of the Antilles, Pointe-à-Pitre, Guadeloupe.

Research

Current Projects

2026- **Form-Function Convergence in LLM Language Acquisition**.
Adapting Baptista, Gelman & Beck's (2016) convergence hypothesis to a language model, using frozen embedding manipulation to make L1–L2 form–function alignment a controlled variable. Convergent morphemes are acquired faster in both production and comprehension, but the effect reverses when the borrowed L1 form is an ambiguous cue to its function. *Collaborators: Marlyse Baptista, Lyle Ungar, Margaret Kandel, and Yourdanis Sedarous.*

Master's Thesis

2026 **Complementation in Guadeloupean Creole: An Experimental and Computational Account**.
Investigated variation in the overt complementizer *kè* through a binary-choice grammaticality judgment task administered in Guadeloupe to 20 GC–French bilinguals, combined with an NLP pipeline over transcribed ethnographic interviews. Adults were highly variable in their use of overt *kè*, while youth showed a consistent slight preference for the null complementizer; adults' judgments also diverged from their naturalistic speech. *Supervised by Jaklin Kornfilt.*

NSF Research Fellowship

2024 **Focus Constructions, Complementizer Dropping, and Definite Clause Deixis within Subordinate Clauses in Guadeloupean Creole**.
Field research documenting syntactic phenomena in Guadeloupean Creole. Combined expertise in computational linguistics and syntactic theory to create three experiments, evaluating speaker intuitions and eliciting complex constructions. (NSF Award No. 1952501) *Supervised by Isabelle Barrière, Béatrice Jeannot-Fourcaud, and Renauld Govain.* LINK

Relevant Graduate Projects

2025 **Referent Tracking and Nonbinary "They" in Apparent Time: Age Effects and the Role of Gender Cues**.
Designed a psycholinguistic storyboard narration task, revealing a generational gap in referent tracking strategies and accuracy with nonbinary they.

2025 **NLP methods for low-resource language documentation: A case study on Guadeloupean Creole**.
Developed a custom grapheme-to-phoneme (G2P) model for Guadeloupean Creole, achieving a 2.8% Phoneme Error Rate, vastly outperforming pre-trained models.

2024 **The Passives were Analyzed: Comparing model performance in classifying passive use in news headline bias**.
Fine-tuned BERT and ChatGPT models to classify media bias in headlines, focusing on passive voice and agent omission. Achieved 89% accuracy with fine-tuned models.

Teaching Experience

2025-2026 **Instructor of Record,** FRENCH 102, Syracuse University
2025 **Instructor of Record,** FRENCH 201, Syracuse University
2023-2024 **Instructor,** Advanced American Culture and English Language, UMass Amherst
2022-2023 **Instructor,** Intermediate American Culture and English Language, UMass Amherst
2022-2024 **ESL Tutor,** UMass Amherst ESL Program
2019 **EFL Teaching Assistant,** Lycée Dumont d'Urville, Laplace, Caen, France

Employment

2025-2026	**Teaching Assistantship,** French and Francophone Program, Syracuse University
2024-2025	**NSF-IRES Research Fellow - Experimental Linguistics in the Caribbean,** University of the Antilles, Guadeloupe LINK
2022-2024	**Teaching Internship,** ESL Program, UMass Amherst
2023-2024	**French Translator,** UMass Daily Collegian
2023	**Multilingual Editor,** mOthertongue Journal of the Arts, UMass Amherst
2023	**French Translator,** the International Rescue Committee

Professional Development

2024	**ToBI Prosody Course,** MIT
2023	**Programming for Everybody (Python),** University of Michigan
2023	**Data structures (Python),** University of Michigan

Awards & Fellowships

2026-	Benjamin Franklin Fellowship, University of Pennsylvania (full tuition & stipend)
2026	The Milkatu Garba Memorial Award for Field Linguistics, Syracuse University
2025	Professional, Academic, and Creative (PAC) Work Grant, Syracuse University, $600
2025	CAS-LLL Summer Research Fellowship, Syracuse University, $375
2024	French Teaching Assistantship, Syracuse University
2024	Tuition Scholarship, Syracuse University
2024	National Science Foundation IRES Fellowship, $1,500 LINK
2023	Luise Bonner Scholarship Fund, $1,420
2023	Phi Kappa Phi Honors Society
2022	Alpha Lambda Delta Honors Society

Skills and Certifications

Programming	Python, R, JavaScript, Bash
Technical Skills	LaTeX, Praat, PsychoPy, ToBI
Certifications	CITI Program - IRB/Human Subjects Research (Social & Behavioral)

Languages

Native	English
Advanced	French
Intermediate	Haitian Creole, Japanese
Fieldwork	Guadeloupean Creole